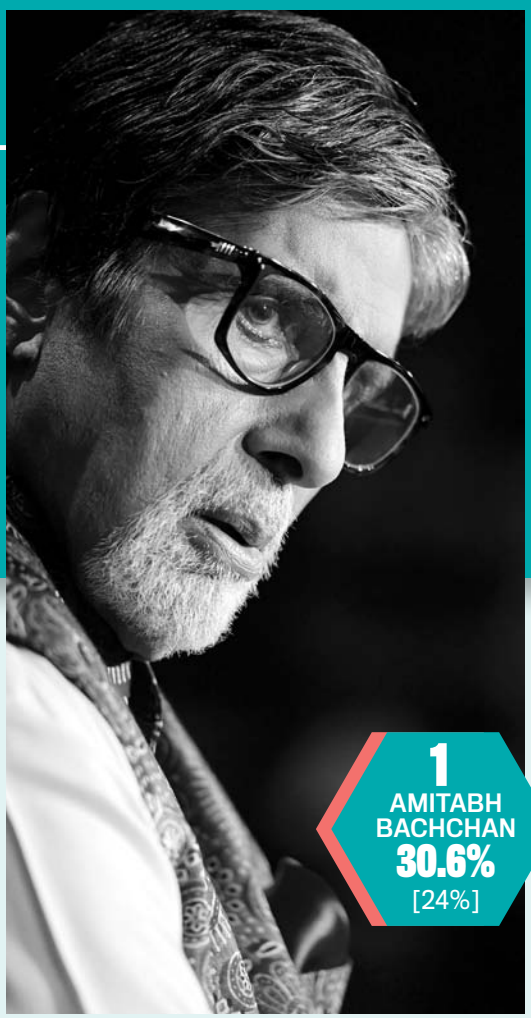
TAKING THE LEAD

Actresses in their 40s are topping the OTT chart, while the Bachchan father and son hold on to pole positions in both the general and OTT categories

By **SUHANI SINGH**



PARESH MEHTA

In the entertainment world, actors know that "being seen" is "being relevant", whether it is getting papped at the airport or sharing a selfie from the Maldives. Katrina Kaif topped the MOTN poll for the first time since 2014 not simply for her role in the action drama *Sooryavanshi*, Hindi cinema's biggest hit of 2021, but also because of her three-day wedding extravaganza that dominated headlines for almost a month. The entry of 'Vicktrina' (the 'Vick' referring to her actor-husband Vicky Kaushal) to a landscape that includes other celebrity couplings—'Virushka' and 'Deepveer'—and Kaif's jig in *Sooryavanshi* to a remixed version of 'Tip Tip Barsa Paani', which has garnered over 200 million views on YouTube, ensured that the 38-year-old ended Deepika Padukone's seven-year reign at the top.

Raveena Tandon made her streaming debut with the Netflix series *Aranyak*, which led to her debuting in the OTT star (female) category. In doing so, she trumped Sushmita Sen, the second season of whose acclaimed drama *Aarya* (Disney+ Hotstar) also released on December 10. The presence of three 40-something actresses in the top five—Pooja Bhatt being the third for her role in *Bombay Begums*—demonstrates how female-led narratives are thriving on SVOD (special video-on-demand) platforms. It is in stark contrast to the top five heroines, of whom only one has done a substantial role since the last edition of the MOTN poll—Kangana Ranaut in *Thalaivi*.

Where men are concerned, Amitabh Bachchan only consolidated his No.1 ranking. The 79-year-old's October release, *Chehre*, may have fizzled at the box office, but on the small screen, he entertained families as the genial host of *Kaun Banega*

Q. WHO IS THE NO.1 HERO IN THE COUNTRY?



AKSHAY KUMAR
12%
[18%*]



SALMAN KHAN
7%
[8%]



SHAH RUKH KHAN
5.2%
[9%]



RAJINIKANTH
3.9%
[10%]